Step One: Apply to an SEVP-Certified School

Your first step is to apply to a Student and Exchange Visitor Program (SEVP)-certified school in the United States. Use the School Search tool to find SEVP-certified schools and programs that are eligible to enroll F-1 and M-1 students.

Step Two: Receive a Form I-20

Once you are accepted into an SEVP-certified school, your school's designated school official will send you a document called the Form I-20, "Certificate of Eligibility for Nonimmigrant Student Status." The Form I-20 is a record of your information in the Student and Exchange Visitor Information System (SEVIS) database. Each school that accepts you will send you a Form I-20.

For more information, visit the Students and the Form I-20 page.

Step Three: Pay the I-901 SEVIS Fee

After receiving your Form I-20, you must pay the I-901 SEVIS Fee before applying for your U.S. student visa. You can pay your I-901 SEVIS Fee online at FMJfee.com or by using Western Union Quick Pay. You must present the receipt as proof of payment when you apply for a visa. It's important that the SEVIS ID number on your I-901 SEVIS Fee receipt matches your SEVIS ID number on your Form I-20. If it does not, or you encounter other issues paying your fee, please contact SEVP.

Learn more about the I-901 SEVIS Fee on Study in the States:

- Paying the I-901 SEVIS Fee
- I-901 SEVIS Fee Payment Tutorial
- I-901 SEVIS Fee FAQs on ICE.gov

Step Four: Apply for Student Visa

After paying the I-901 SEVIS Fee and getting a receipt, you must apply for a visa at any U.S. Embassy or Consulate before you come to the United States. Bring your Form I-20 and other required documents to apply for a student visa from the U.S. Department of State.

A visa does not guarantee entrance to the United States; it only permits you to arrive and seek permission to enter the country. The U.S. Customs and Border Protection (CBP) officer at the U.S. port of entry has the final authority to admit entry into the country.

Learn more about the student visa process:

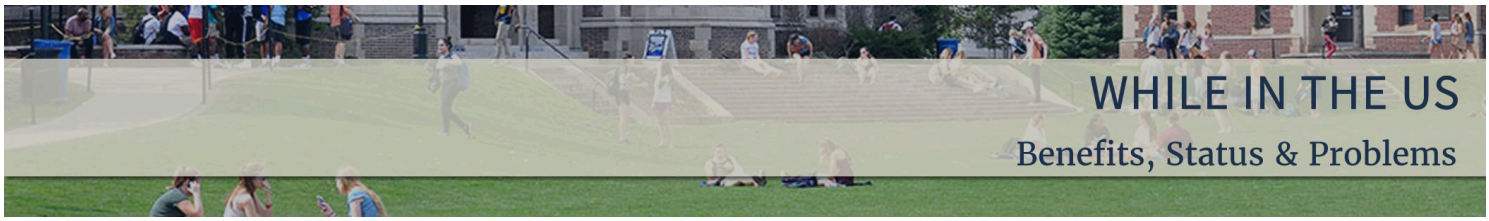
- U.S. Department of State Visas (for F or M visas)
- Exchange Visitors (J visa)

Step Five: Arrive in the United States

Before you leave for the United States, make sure you are familiar with the documents you will need, or may need, when you arrive. For more information on traveling to the United States, visit the Getting to the United States page.

When you arrive to the United States you will meet a Customs and Border Protection (CBP) officer at the port of entry, who will verify your information and determine if you may enter the country. Learn more about what to expect a U.S. port of entry and what happens if you are referred to Secondary inspection or receive a Form I-515A, "Notice to Student or Exchange Visitor. If the CBP officer admits you into the country, they will give you a Form I-94, "Arrival/Departure Record."

You have 30 days to enter the country before your official program start date listed on your Form I-20. If you cannot enter the United States for the start date on your Form I-20, contact your school officials immediately so they can update your record in SEVIS to reflect your changed plan.



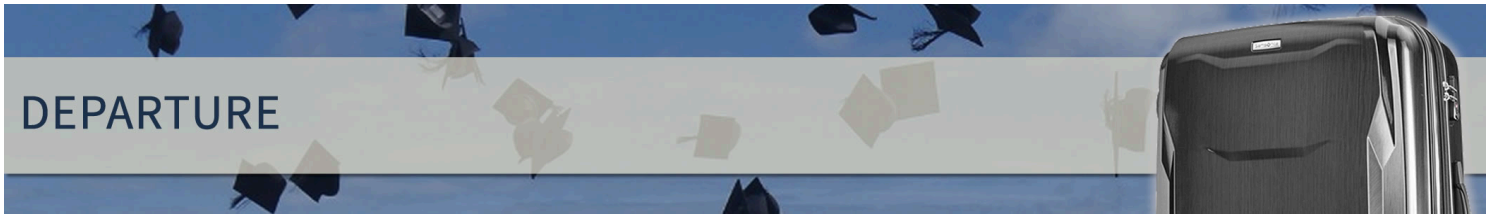
Step Six: Maintain Student Status

To maintain your student status, you must fulfill the purpose for your visa and follow all associated regulations. Learn more about the rules by talking to your DSO and reviewing the Maintaining Status page on Study in the States.

While studying in the United States, you may be eligible to apply for certain benefits. Students must apply to other government agencies to receive them and eligibility depends on your student status. Visit the following pages to learn more about potential student benefits:

- Driving in the United States
- Working in the United States
- Training Opportunities in the United States
- Obtaining a Social Security Number

As a note, most employment and training opportunities require authorization from United States Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS). For more information, visit the Employment page on ICE.gov.



Step Seven: Explore Post Graduation Opportunities

Once you complete your program and fulfill your purpose for coming to the United States, you have several options. These include changing your status, applying for practical training, transferring to another SEVP-certified school or leaving the country.

Restrictions may apply to M students transferring and changing status. Talk to your DSO to understand your options.

Step Eight: Depart the United States

If you do not qualify to stay in the country after completing your program, or chose to depart, please remember:

- F-1 students and dependents have 60 days after program end date (or training end date) to depart the United States.
- M-1 students and dependents have 30 days after program end date (or training end date) to depart the United States.

Study in the States

Explanation of rules & regulations governing the nonimmigrant student process

Updated: 07/08/2025

CONTACT

Contact SEVIS

sevp@ice.dhs.gov

SEVIS Help Hub

SEVP Response Center: (703) 603-3400 • 8 a.m. - 6 p.m. ET weekdays, except holidays

LATEST NEWS

News Releases About SEVP

RELATED INFORMATION

SEVP Overview

Schools

SEVIS

Conferences & Outreach

I-901 SEVIS Fee

Operating Instructions

What's New

IMPORTANT LINKS

Practical Training

SEVP-Certified Schools

Working While in the U.S.

How Do I Become an F or M Student

Transfers for F-1 Students

Study in the States Site Index

SEVP Portal